I visited again in late 2018, arriving by an overnight train from Bengaluru to Hospet. According to Domingo Paes, who visited in the early sixteenth century, Hospet, then Nagalapur, was a new satellite city built by Krishnadevaraya for his favourite wife, who had also been his lover in his youth when she was a courtesan. This new city lay within a fortified wall of stone, the outermost of the seven walls to be built around Vijayanagar. All visitors from the western side passed a gateway here, continuing to Vijayanagar on a wide, tree-lined road with houses and shops where, wrote one European visitor, they sold 'everything'.[1] Medieval Nagalapur and its walls and gateway are no more. Hospet is now yet another dusty, noisy small Indian city struggling with ill-planned urban growth and traffic congestion.

The first morning in Hospet, I catch a city bus from near my hotel to Hampi, 13 km and forty minutes away. As elsewhere in south India, I notice women in much higher proportions in the bus and in other public spaces compared to northern cities. They often have fresh flowers in their braids, a custom noticed by travellers even in Vijayanagar times. We pass many villages and stretches of lovely green vistas of coconut and banana plantations, sugarcane fields and rice paddies. We cross the ruins of a few Vijayanagar-era shrines and mandapas and a large reservoir that once supplied water to the imperial city and is still in use. We then reach the tourist village of Kamalapur, close to the ruins at Hampi and home to yet another ASI site museum that prevents tourists from taking photos of its artefacts for no good reason.

Even in its ruined state, Vijayanagar is overwhelming. It's spread over 30 sq. km of a dazzling, boulder-strewn landscape south of the languid Tungabhadra River, whose wildness was tamed by a mega dam upriver, near Hospet. A wide range of stone buildings survive in various stages of repair in two primary zones: a northern Sacred Centre and a southern 'urban core', the latter largely residential and including the Royal Centre. Both zones, with all of the blockbuster sites frequented by tourists, have numerous thick walls, gateways and watchtowers. Between the two zones was, and still is, an agricultural zone, fed by a canal that's still in use.

The Sacred Centre abounds in temples and shrines, many adjacent to former bazaars and pavilions. These include the Virupaksha Temple,